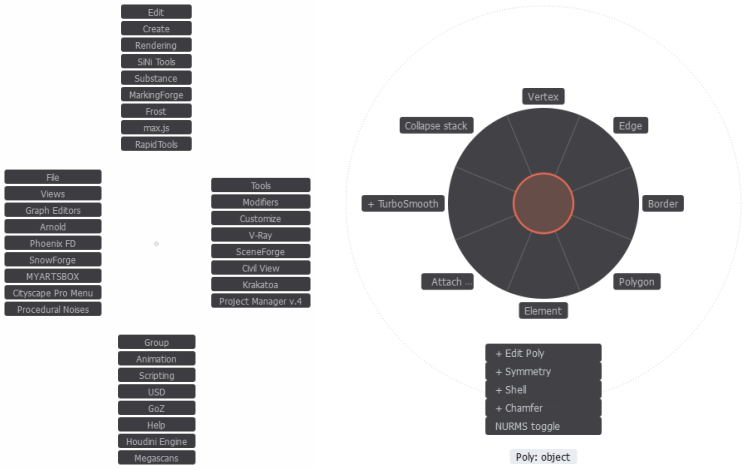
MarkingForge

for Maya users - your marking menus and hotbox, in 3ds Max

3DS MAX 2027 · VERSION 1.5.59



REAL MARKING MENUS - A QUICK GESTURE NEEDS NO DIAL

MarkingForge works the way marking menus are meant to: the command is chosen by the **direction** of the movement, not by clicking an item. Press the key and flick the mouse towards the command in one quick movement - the command runs and **the dial is not even drawn**. The dial appears only when you hold the key and wait, to remind you where things are. After a few days your hand knows the directions and you stop looking.

If your hand already knows Maya's marking menus, it already knows MarkingForge: hold, aim, release. This guide maps what you know from Maya to where it lives here, and sets 3ds Max up the way a Maya user expects in five minutes.

Contents

1. You already know how this works
2. Maya habit - MarkingForge equivalent
3. Set 3ds Max up like Maya in five minutes
4. Differences worth knowing
5. A two-week plan for a Maya hand
6. Support, bug reports and feature requests

You already know how this works

MarkingForge brings the interaction you use in Maya every day into 3ds Max, the same way round:

IN MAYA		IN MARKINGFORGE
Hold a key or a mouse button, a radial menu appears, drag towards an item, release. Experienced users flick without looking at the menu.	→	Exactly that. Hold a key, the dial appears, aim, release - or flick without waiting for the dial. Release in the centre to cancel.
Eight compass positions, plus extra items in a list under the marking menu; sub-menus open by dragging through an item.	→	Eight directions, plus up to twelve rows under the dial; submenus open by moving through their direction, three levels deep.
The right-click marking menu changes with what is under the cursor and with the component mode.	→	Context variants: the same key shows different tools at vertex, edge or polygon level, on a spline, over the material editor - automatically.
Hold Space: the hotbox shows every menu at the cursor.	→	The hotbox dial shows every 3ds Max menu as tiles at the cursor - including menus other plugins add. Put it on Space if you like (chapter 3).
More marking menus from the same place: each zone of the hotbox has its own marking menus, one per mouse button.	→	One key can hold several sets of a dial - its pages. Hold the key and turn the mouse wheel: the next or previous page appears in place ("page 2 of 3" under the dial). The next press opens the page you turned to last.

Maya habit - MarkingForge equivalent

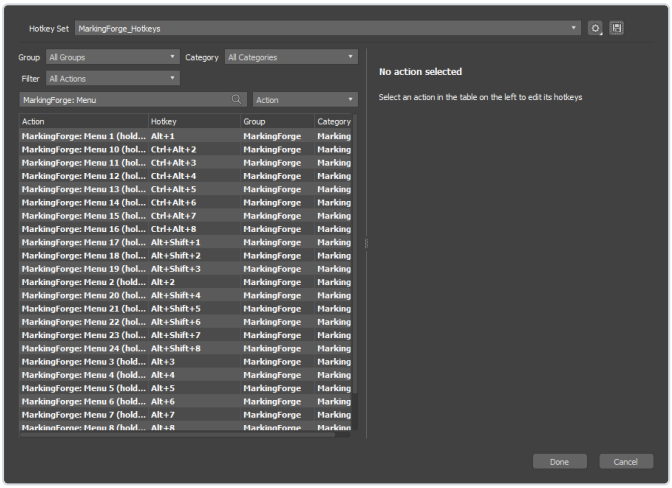
In Maya you...	In MarkingForge	Notes
Hold Space for the hotbox	Alt+5, one mouse-wheel notch away (the hotbox page)	Or put the hotbox dial from the dial library on a key of its own - Space, chapter 3.
Right-click an object to pick a component mode	Alt+1 on an Editable Poly at object level: Vertex N, Edge NE, Border E, Polygon SE, Element S	3ds Max's own keys 1-5 still work.
Shift + right-click for the modelling tools of the current component	Alt+1 at a sub-object level: vertex / edge / border / polygon / element tools	Same directions on Editable Poly and under Edit Poly - except W at polygon level (Detach / Bridge). NW goes back to object level.
Ctrl + right-click to convert the selection	Alt+3 at a sub-object level of an Editable Poly: To vertex, To edge, To face on three corners	Grow / Shrink and Loop / Ring are on the same dial.
Grow / shrink the component selection	Alt+3 at a sub-object level: Grow N, Shrink S	
Click an item's option box to set it up first	Move far past the ring before releasing: Chamfer, Extrude, Inset... open their settings (caddy); an ordinary release runs them at once - and a long flick counts as far	Per item: Settings... in the editor chooses which is the default.
Repeat the last command	Alt+8 (Recent commands), north is the newest	A flick up repeats.
Undo several steps	Alt+7 (Undo): each direction undoes more steps, by name	N = 1 step, NE = 2 ...
Frame the selection / frame all	Ctrl+Alt+7: Zoom selected SW, Zoom extents all N	3ds Max's Z key also frames the selection.
Isolate the selection	Ctrl+Alt+7: Isolate S	The same move ends the isolation.
Switch between perspective and orthographic views	Ctrl+Alt+8 (Viewports): a compass of views	Top N, Bottom S, Left W, Right E, Front SE, Back SW, Perspective NE, Camera NW.
Create primitives from a marking menu	Alt+4 (Create)	Shapes when a shape is selected.
Reach several marking menus from one place (the hotbox zones)	Sets of one dial: hold its key and turn the mouse wheel	Add a set in the editor with **New set...** or **Dial library...** > **Add as a new set of Menu N**; each set has a tab over the dial's contents.
Build your own marking menu in the Marking Menu Editor	MarkingForge > Menu editor...	Any of 4000+ 3ds Max commands, 102 ready-made scripts, your own scripts, submenus. Or start from **Dial library...** or **New dial wizard...**
Take your marking menus to another machine	Right-click a dial in the editor: save it to a .mfdial file, or **Save every dial...**	On the other machine: **Load dial...** or **Load every dial...**. Scripts from somebody else's files are removed unless you keep them.
Give a marking menu a hotkey (press / release)	Set shortcut... + Apply shortcuts	Or 3ds Max's Customize > Hotkey Editor: MarkingForge: Menu 1-24.
Put a marking menu on a mouse button	Mouse button (+ Ctrl / Alt / Shift) in the editor	A modifier is required - chapter 4 explains why.

Set 3ds Max up like Maya in five minutes

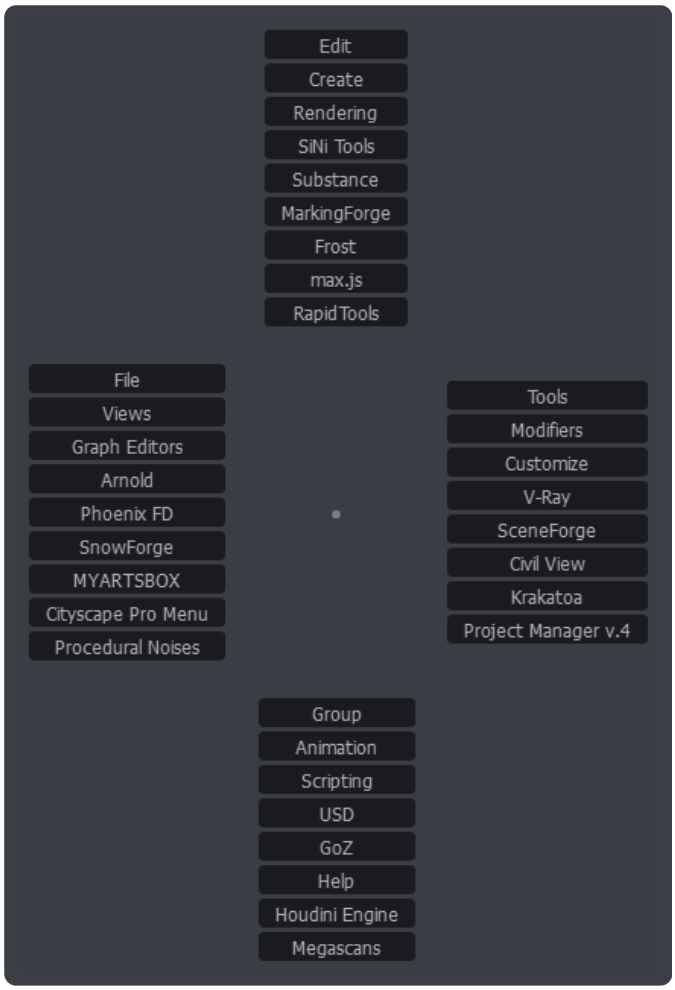
1. The hotbox on Space

In 3ds Max, Space toggles the selection lock. If you do not use that, give Space to the hotbox - the selection lock stays one gesture away on Alt+3 (west).

1. **Customize > Hotkey Editor**.
2. Type `MarkingForge: Menu 5` in the search field and select it.
3. Click the hotkey field on the right, press **Space** and assign it. 3ds Max tells you Space is used by Selection Lock Toggle - reassign.
4. **Done**. Hold Space in a viewport and turn the mouse wheel one notch away from you: the hotbox.



The Hotkey Editor filtered to the MarkingForge dials.



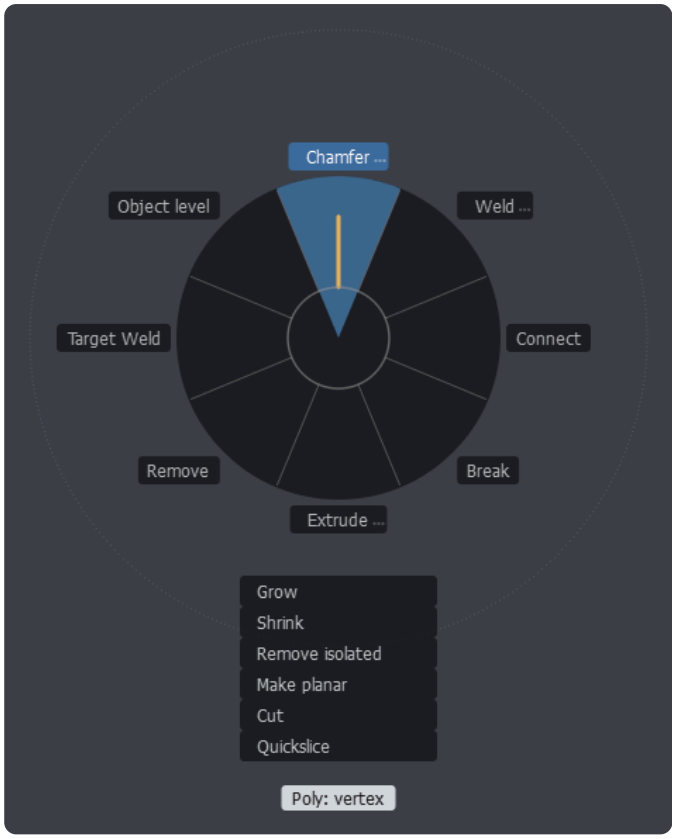
The hotbox - 3ds Max's menus around the cursor.

2. Component modes and tools under one key

Nothing to set up - Alt+1 already behaves like Maya's right-click and Shift + right-click menus combined. On an Editable Poly at object level it offers the component levels; at a level it offers that level's tools.

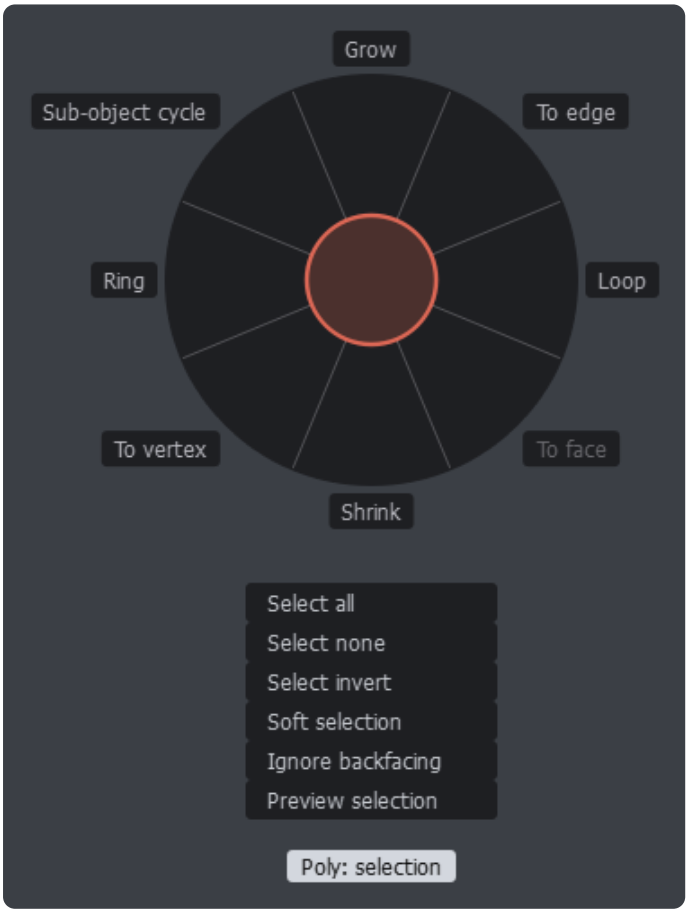


Alt+1 at object level: pick the component mode.



Alt+1 at vertex level: the vertex tools.

3. Selection conversion and growing

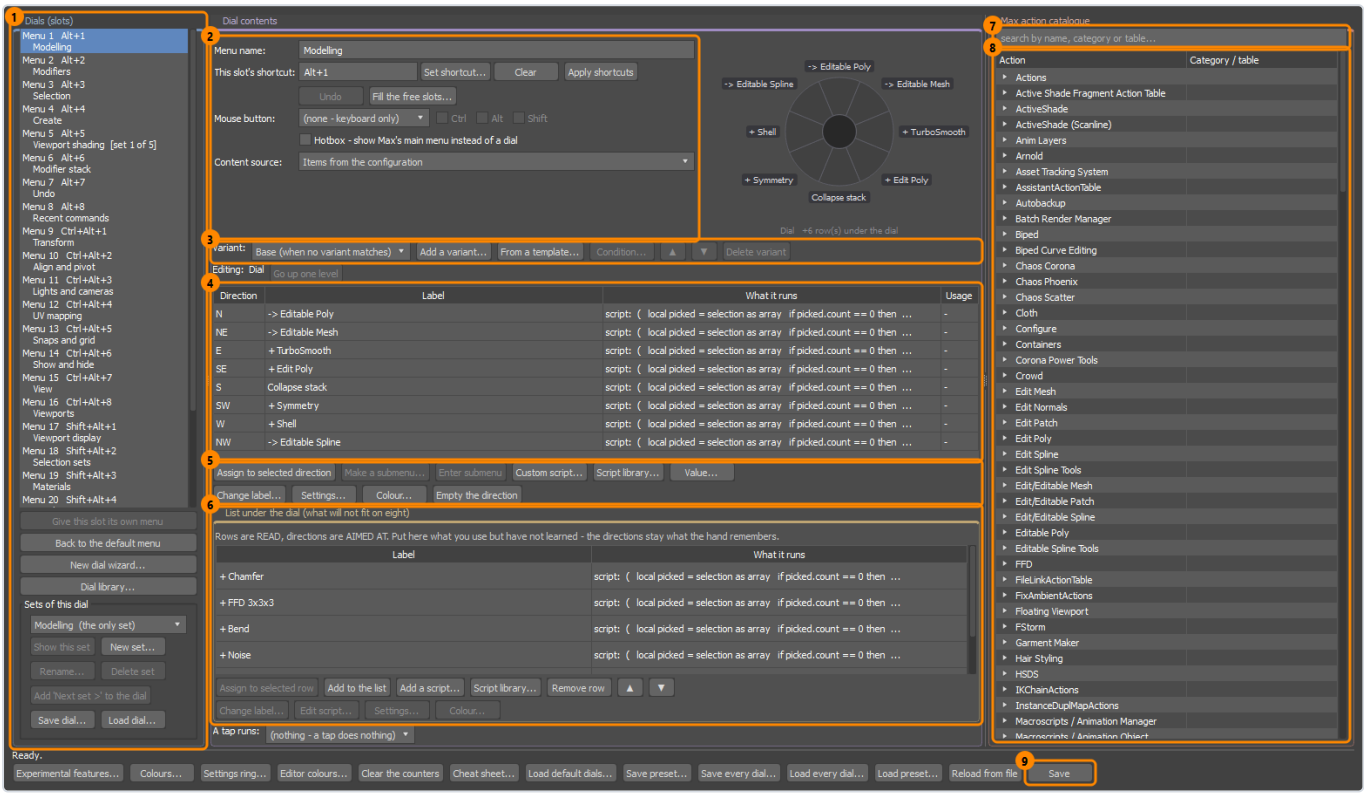


Alt+3 at a component level: Grow / Shrink, Loop / Ring, conversions on the corners.

4. Your most used Maya menu, rebuilt

Open **MarkingForge > Menu editor...**, pick an empty or rarely used dial and place your commands. The QuickStart Long walks through it step by step (lessons 8-13).

Want to keep the dial that is there? Make your menu a **new set** of it instead (**New set...** under **Sets of this dial**): the key still opens what it opened, and the mouse wheel turns to your menu while you hold the key. **Put this set on the key** swaps them when your menu has earned the first place. The QuickStart Long covers sets and the dial library in lessons 20 and 21.



The menu editor: dials, directions, and the catalogue of every 3ds Max command.

Differences worth knowing

Topic	What is different	Why
Right-click menus	Dials open on keys (or a mouse button WITH a modifier), not on a bare right-click.	In 3ds Max the right button opens the quad menu and every modifier + right-click combination opens another quad. Taking a bare mouse button away from 3ds Max would break it, so MarkingForge refuses.
Free mouse combinations	Good choices: a thumb button (XB1 / XB2) with Ctrl or Shift, or Ctrl+Shift + middle button.	Alt + middle orbits and Ctrl+Alt + middle zooms in 3ds Max.
The hotbox	Shows 3ds Max's main menu as tiles; you point at a menu title, then at an entry and release - or click the entry, as in Maya.	The MarkingForge hotbox has no marking-menu zones like Maya's - the 24 dials and their pages under the mouse wheel play that role.
Option boxes	An ordinary release runs the command at once by default; far past the ring opens its settings. A flick follows the same ring: short runs it, long opens the settings.	Configurable per item with Settings... in the editor; the ring's distance with Settings ring...
Context	Chosen automatically from the sub-object level, the selection, the modifier in the panel or the window under the cursor.	The first matching variant wins - you control the order in the editor.
How many menus	24 dials on Alt, Ctrl+Alt and Shift+Alt with digits 1-8 - and any dial can hold several sets, turned with the mouse wheel.	The digit is the place, the modifier the bank - easy to count to without looking.
The mouse wheel	Taken only while a dial with sets is open and at its first level - it turns the page. In a submenu, the hotbox or any other time it zooms and scrolls as usual.	One page per notch, also on a fine wheel or a touchpad.

> 3ds Max already uses **Q W E R** for select, move, rotate and scale - the same keys as Maya - so those habits carry over without MarkingForge.

A two-week plan for a Maya hand

When	Do this
Day 1	Hotbox on Space. Use Alt+1 for component modes and tools instead of the command panel.
Days 2-4	Alt+3 for selection conversion, Ctrl+Alt+7 for framing and isolating. Print the Shortcut Card.
Days 5-7	Flick the gestures you use most without waiting for the dial.
Week 2	Rebuild your one or two favourite Maya marking menus as MarkingForge dials in the editor - or as a second page of a dial you already use, one wheel notch away.

Next: the **QuickStart Long** (22 lessons with pictures) - or the **QuickStart Short**, about 15 minutes - and the **Reference** (every option).

Support, bug reports and feature requests

ISSUES	github.com/Forge-Plugins/MarkingForge/issues
ROADMAP	trello.com/b/7gJVqG8Y/markingforge-features-roadmap
E-MAIL	forgeplugins@gmail.com
WEB	https://forgeplugins.tech (forgeplugins.tech - more plugins by the author)

Bug reports and feature requests are best opened as issues on GitHub - the forms there ask for exactly what is needed, and you can follow the fix. Questions, and anything you would rather not post publicly (licence, purchase), go to the e-mail address. Every message is read.

Reporting a bug

1. In 3ds Max choose **MarkingForge > Report a bug...** - it copies your 3ds Max version, MarkingForge version, configuration summary and start-up log to the clipboard. It works even when the plugin did not load.
2. Open github.com/Forge-Plugins/MarkingForge/issues and pick **Bug report** - or write an e-mail to forgeplugins@gmail.com instead. Both are links in the window that opens (since 1.5.20), one click each.
3. Say what you did, what you expected and what happened instead, then paste the details with **Ctrl+V**.
4. Add a screenshot if you can. When the problem is in one dial, attach a preset of it (editor > **Save preset...**).

Suggesting a feature

Open an issue with the **Feature request** form, choose **MarkingForge > Suggest a feature...**, or simply write. Describe what you would like to do and how you do it today - a concrete example from your work says more than a list of wishes. Ideas for new built-in dials, commands and options are all welcome. What is already planned and in progress is on the **Roadmap** above - **MarkingForge > Roadmap (Trello)** opens it too.

Nothing is sent by the plugin itself: the details go to the clipboard and your own e-mail program, so you see everything that leaves your computer. MarkingForge has no network access.